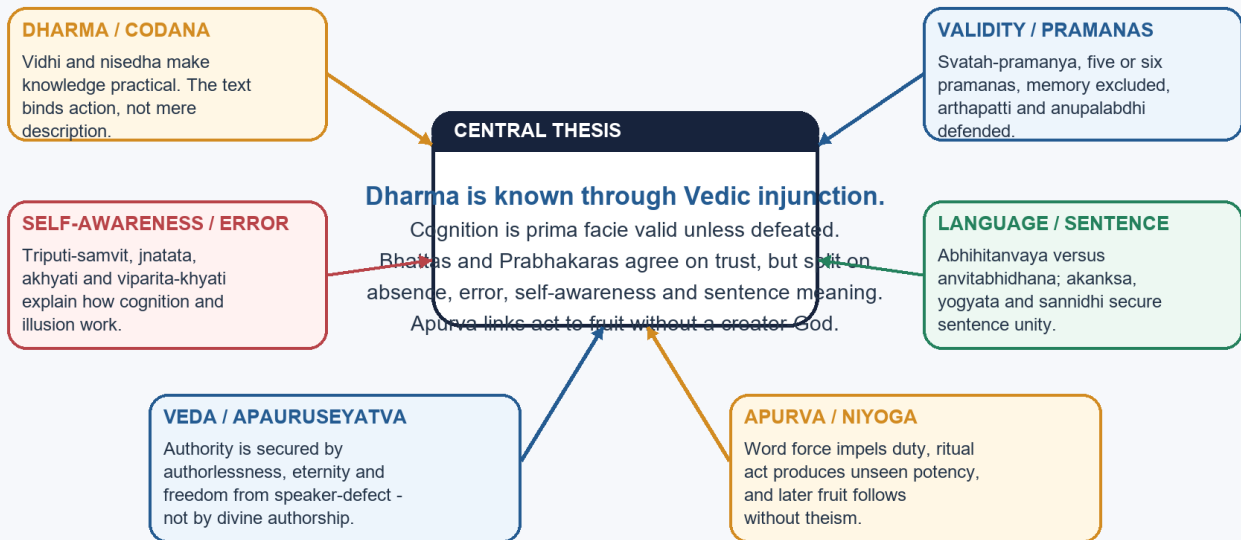


MIMAMSA - Layered Session Premium Solved-PYQ and Practice Workbook

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MIMAMSA: KNOWLEDGE IN DEFENCE OF DHARMA

Validity, language, injunction, absence, error and apurva in one exam map



SPINE: default trust -> special pramanas -> language and injunction -> apurva -> criticism and graded validity

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

MIMAMSA - Layered Session Premium Solved-PYQ and Practice Workbook

SOLVED PYQ WORKBOOK - ALL 14 VERIFIED QUESTIONS

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: Does the admission of Svayaṃprakāśavāda necessarily lead to the admission of Svataḥprāmāṇyavāda? Discuss after the Naiyāyikas, the Mīmāṃsakas and the Advaita Vedāntins.

Model solution

The relation is close but **not logically necessary**. **Svayaṃprakāśavāda** concerns how cognition or consciousness becomes manifest; **svataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda** concerns whether cognition carries its own prima facie validity. Manifestation and validity therefore address two different questions.

The **Naiyāyikas** deny both theses. A cognition is known through a later **anuvyavasāya**, and its validity is established extrinsically through correspondence, successful action or later confirmation. For Nyāya, immediate appearance does not yet amount to certified truth.

Among the **Mīmāṃsakas**, the issue divides sharply. **Prābhākara** supports a strong form of self-revelation through **tripuṭī-samvit**: knower, known and knowledge appear together. He also supports intrinsic validity, because another validating cognition would generate regress. Here self-luminosity and intrinsic validity travel together.

But **Kumārila Bhaṭṭa** breaks any claim of necessity. He too accepts intrinsic validity: cognition is trusted unless defeated by later contradiction or defect-awareness. Yet he denies that cognition is self-luminous. Cognition is known through the object's **jñātātā** or cognizedness. Thus one may defend svataḥ-prāmāṇya without accepting svayaṃprakāśa.

Advaita Vedānta complicates the issue further. Advaita strongly affirms self-luminous consciousness, but its final subject is not merely episodic cognition; it is consciousness as such, ultimately ātman-Brahman. Empirical cognitions function as valid until sublated, but Advaita's deepest self-luminosity thesis is metaphysical rather than merely epistemic. Hence the inference from self-revelation to intrinsic validity still requires argument.

School	Self-luminosity?	Intrinsic validity?	Result
Nyāya	No	No	both denied
Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā	Yes	Yes	close linkage
Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā	No	Yes	decisive counterexample to necessity
Advaita	Yes, at the level of consciousness itself	broad presumption of validity until sublation	related, but not a simple entailment

Conclusion: self-luminosity may support intrinsic validity, but it does not necessarily entail it. The Bhāṭṭa position proves that a thinker may deny self-luminosity and still defend intrinsic validity; therefore the two doctrines must be kept conceptually distinct.

Why this earns marks: It separates manifestation from validity, compares all three requested schools, and uses the Bhāṭṭa position as the decisive argument against any claim of strict entailment.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: How does Mīmāṃsā establish the authority of Vedic knowledge?

Model solution

Mīmāṃsā establishes Vedic authority through **apauruṣeyatva**, **śabda-nityatva**, and the special domain of **dharma**. The Veda is authoritative because it is **authorless**, eternal and therefore free from the defects that affect personal testimony - ignorance, deception, forgetfulness or partiality. A human or divine author would introduce precisely the kind of locus of error that Mīmāṃsā wants to exclude.

The school also treats the relation between word and meaning as **autpattika**, natural or inherent, not a convention imposed by an institutor. Words are manifested in utterance rather than created anew. Hence the Veda does not depend for its authority on a historical act of composition.

Most importantly, the Veda has a unique object: **dharma**, which is supersensible. Perception and inference can tell us about ordinary worldly objects, but not about ritual duty and unseen fruit. Therefore Vedic testimony is indispensable in its own sphere. Testimony of a reliable person may also yield knowledge, but Vedic knowledge has a superior status because its object cannot be known otherwise.

Nyāya tries to secure scripture through God as an omniscient author. Mīmāṃsā rejects this as unnecessary and weaker: one would first have to prove God's existence, omniscience and sincerity. Authorlessness is thus the school's stronger route.

Why this earns marks: It states the three core supports - apauruṣeyatva, eternality and unique revelatory scope - and directly contrasts the Mimamsa strategy with Nyāya's God-author model.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Why is memory not a valid knowledge according to Mīmāṃsā?

Model solution

Mīmāṃsā denies pramāṇa-status to memory because memory does **not** generate a previously unknown cognition. A valid means of knowledge must disclose an object with novelty and present epistemic force. Memory depends on an earlier cognition and a residual impression; it merely reproduces what has already been known.

This is why recollection is different from perception or inference. Perception reveals an object directly here and now. Inference yields a fresh mediate cognition. Memory, by contrast, only re-presents past content. It may be true, useful and practically important, but its truth is derivative from the original cognition on which it rests.

Both **Prābhākara** and **Nyāya** agree on this point. The dependence of memory on prior apprehension is exactly what disqualifies it from being a fresh source of valid knowledge.

Conclusion: memory is not false simply because it is memory; it is excluded because it lacks the novelty required of a pramāṇa.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact exclusion criterion, distinguishes memory from fresh cognition, and avoids the trap of treating memory as false rather than merely non-pramāṇic.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 Q6(c), 15 marks

Question: What, according to Mīmāṃsakas, is the ontological status of abhāva (absence) and how does one know it? Explain and examine.

Model solution

For the **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas**, **abhāva** is real enough to be the object of determinate cognition. When I say, "there is no jar on the floor," I am not merely ignorant of a jar; I positively know its absence. That cognition is structured by a **pratiyogin**, the counterpositive whose absence is at issue.

Bhāṭṭa therefore accepts **anupalabdhi** as an independent pramāṇa. The classic formula is: absence is known through **non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present**. This requires **yogyānupalabdhi** - fitness conditions such as proper light, functioning sense-organ, available locus and appropriate attention. Only then does non-perception disclose absence.

Prābhākara resists a separate anupalabdhi. He explains the case as perception of the bare locus unqualified by the absent object. **Nyāya** also rejects an independent anupalabdhi, though it accepts absence as ontologically significant and handles it through perception or inference.

View	Status of abhāva	How known?
Bhāṭṭa	real negative entity/content	anupalabdhi
Prābhākara	not denied, but no new pramāṇa required	bare-locus cognition
Nyāya	real category	perception or inference, not separate anupalabdhi

Examination: Bhāṭṭa preserves the determinacy of negative cognition very well, but at the price of both a richer ontology and a new pramāṇa. Prābhākara is more economical, but critics ask whether “bare locus” really explains the judgment “the jar is absent.”

Verdict: the Bhāṭṭa account is stronger if one wants to preserve the full objecthood of absence; the Prābhākara account is stronger if one prioritizes ontological and epistemic economy.

Why this earns marks: It presents both the ontological and epistemic sides of the issue, gives the fitness condition for absence-knowledge, and ends with a balanced evaluative comparison.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022 Q6(c), 15 marks

Question: How do Mīmāṃsakas refute the Nyāya view that Implication (arthāpatti) is reducible to Inference (anumāna) and establish Implication as an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Mīmāṃsā treats **arthāpatti** as a distinct pramāṇa because it arises from **explanatory compulsion**, not from the sign-based structure of inference. The standard case is: “Devadatta is stout, and Devadatta does not eat during the day.” To preserve both accepted facts, one must postulate that Devadatta eats at night.

The Nyāya reduction attempts to turn this into inference:

- all stout persons who do not eat by day eat by night;
- Devadatta is stout and does not eat by day;
- therefore Devadatta eats by night.

Mīmāṃsā objects on three grounds. First, the alleged **vyāpti** is not independently known; it is abstracted from the very explanatory tension that arthāpatti is supposed to solve. Second, inference moves from **hetu** to **sādhya**, whereas arthāpatti moves from **incompatible accepted facts** to a postulate that alone makes them coherent. Third, the arthāpatti case lacks the normal **pakṣa-hetu-sādhya** structure.

Kumārila therefore insists that arthāpatti is not a weak guess or provisional hypothesis. It yields the one fact without which the data remain untenable. Chatterjee and Datta put the point sharply: a hypothesis remains tentative, but arthāpatti carries conviction as the only viable explanation.

Critical discussion: Nyāya can often reconstruct such cases inferentially, and that is why the debate survives. But the Mimamsa claim is that the inferential reconstruction is parasitic on a prior recognition of explanatory incompatibility. If that is right, arthāpatti deserves independent status.

Verdict: arthāpatti is best defended as the epistemic form of explanatory necessity; whether one grants it full independence depends on whether one thinks inferential reformulation captures or merely redescribes that necessity.

Why this earns marks: It states the Nyāya reduction fairly, gives the three standard Mimamsa objections, uses the Devadatta case correctly, and ends with a qualified critical verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: In spite of accepting the intrinsic validity of knowledge, why and how Prabhākara and Kumārila differ in their interpretation of erroneous cognition? Discuss.

Model solution

Both Prabhākara and Kumārila accept **svataḥ-prāmāṇya**: cognition is prima facie valid and does not need prior external certification. Yet they diverge because they explain error in different ways.

For **Prabhākara**, the central issue is to preserve the truth of each constituent cognition. In shell-silver illusion, the present shining object is genuinely perceived as “this,” while previously seen silver is genuinely remembered. The error lies in **non-discrimination** between these two valid cognitions. This is **akhyāti** or, more precisely, **vivekākhyāti** - failure to apprehend the difference. No single false cognition needs to be posited.

For **Kumārila**, this is too weak to explain the assertive force of illusion. The subject does not merely have a perception plus a memory; the subject really judges, “this is silver.” Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā therefore accepts a positive misapprehension, **viparīta-khyāti**. A false cognition occurs, but only under defective conditions - poor light, similarity, distance or other causal disturbance. Intrinsic validity is preserved because falsity is not basic; it is **extrinsically occasioned** and later disclosed through correction.

Issue	Prabhākara	Kumārila
Status of constituents	both perception and memory remain valid	a false synthetic cognition occurs
Name of theory	akhyāti / vivekākhyāti	viparīta-khyāti
Strategy for saving intrinsic validity	error lies in non-discrimination, not false cognition	normal cognition remains self-valid; error belongs to defective conditions
Strength	strong anti-skeptical economy	better explanation of the lived assertiveness of illusion
Weakness	seems too weak for “this is silver”	admits real falsity and must explain how default validity survives

Nyāya and Advaita help sharpen the point. Nyāya's **anyathākhyāti** relocates the real silver elsewhere; Advaita's **anirvacanīya-khyāti** treats the illusory object as neither real nor unreal. By contrast, both Mimamsa sub-schools remain broadly realist and anti-skeptical.

Conclusion: the disagreement does not cancel intrinsic validity. It shows two different ways of protecting it - Prabhākara by minimizing falsity, Kumārila by localizing falsity in defect-ridden conditions.

Why this earns marks: It explains why the paradox arises, reconstructs both theories through the shell-silver case, compares their strengths and weaknesses, and ties the whole debate back to intrinsic validity.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: Present Bhāṭṭa's view of anupalabdhi (non-cognition) as a valid means of knowledge.

Model solution

Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā accepts **anupalabdhi** as an independent pramāṇa because determinate absence-cognition cannot, in its view, be reduced either to perception or to inference. When I judge, “the jar is not on the floor,” I do not merely fail to see a jar; I positively know its absence.

The key formula is **yogyānupalabdhi**: non-apprehension of an object that **would** be apprehended if it were present. Four features matter - perceptibility of the object, availability of the locus, functioning sense-organ, and fit conditions such as light and attention. Under these conditions, non-perception becomes cognitively significant.

Bhāṭṭa denies reduction to perception because perception requires contact with a present object. Absence is not a positive sensible object in that way. He denies reduction to inference because the evidentiary force of not-seeing the jar already presupposes the principle that non-apprehension under fit conditions reveals absence; inferential reduction thus becomes circular.

Claim	Bhāṭṭa position
What is known?	a real absence with a counterpositive
How known?	by an independent pramāṇa, anupalabdhi
Limiting condition	only under yogyatā / fitness
Why not perception?	no present positive object is contacted
Why not inference?	inferential force already presupposes anupalabdhi

Critical note: the theory preserves ordinary negative judgments very well, but it multiplies both ontology and pramāṇas. This is why Prābhākara and Nyāya resist it.

Verdict: Bhāṭṭa's anupalabdhi is strongest when one insists that absence-cognition is both determinate and irreducible.

Why this earns marks: It states the exact defining formula, explains the fitness condition, answers both reduction attempts, and ends with the standard critical qualification.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2023 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Do words refer to universals or particulars or both? Present an exposition of Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā position with regard to above question along with suitable examples.

Model solution

The dispute is not over whether language can finally guide us to individuals; it is over **semantic priority**. Mīmāṃsā generally holds that words primarily denote **universals (jāti)**, while Nyāya gives priority to the **qualified individual (vyakti)**.

Mīmāṃsā argues that one and the same word - for example, "cow" - applies across many individual cows. This repeatability is best explained if the word first denotes **cow-ness**. In a concrete context, the universal becomes instantiated in this or that cow, and action then concerns the qualified individual. The school therefore preserves practical reference without surrendering universal meaning.

Nyāya reverses the order. A word refers to an individual that is qualified by universal, form and relational features. This better suits action-language. One milks or brings **this cow**, not a bare universal. The universal is not denied, but it is not the primary referent.

Issue	Mīmāṃsā	Nyāya
Primary denotation	jāti / universal	qualified individual
Main reason	explains repeatable use across many cases	explains concrete action and reference
What is not denied	contextual reach to individuals	role of universals in cognition

Example: in a Vedic sentence about sacrifice, Mīmāṃsā can say the word first conveys the class-character needed for repeatable rule-application; Nyāya insists that actual ritual performance requires a determinate qualified individual.

Conclusion: both schools can reach both universal and individual, but they differ on where semantic explanation should begin. Mīmāṃsā starts from repeatability; Nyāya starts from concrete qualified reference.

Why this earns marks: It gives both positions without caricature, explains the idea of semantic priority, and uses examples that connect ordinary language with ritual application.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: How does Bhāṭṭa's view of nature of word-meaning and sentential-meaning differ from Prābhākara's view? Critically discuss.

Model solution

The difference is captured by the two classic labels **abhihitānvayavāda** and **anvitābhīdhānavāda**.

For **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā**, words first denote their own separate meanings. Sentence-meaning arises later by connecting those already-denoted meanings. Hence the word is the primary semantic unit and the sentence is compositional.

For **Prābhākara**, words do not first present isolated meanings. They signify meanings only as **already connected** within a sentence. The sentence is primary, and isolated lexical meaning is an abstraction from living use.

Issue	Bhāṭṭa	Prābhākara
Theory name	abhihitānvayavāda	anvitābhīdhānavāda
First semantic unit	word	connected sentence-use
Strength	preserves stable lexical meaning	preserves contextual and action-guiding meaning
Main criticism	requires an additional connecting step	risks making isolated word-meaning too dependent on context

Both accept **ākāṅkṣā**, **yogyatā** and **sannidhi** as conditions of sentence-unity. The critical issue is whether sentence meaning is built from prior word-meanings or directly grasped as connected.

Verdict: Bhāṭṭa is stronger on compositional stability; Prābhākara is stronger on lived contextual comprehension.

Why this earns marks: It states both technical terms correctly, gives the difference in one clean table, and ends with a real critical contrast instead of mere paraphrase.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2024 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: How do I know that I know? Answer this question with reference to the Naiyāyikas, the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Prābhākaras.

Model solution

The problem is reflexive awareness: once an object is known, how is the **cognition itself** known? Nyāya, Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā and Prābhākara offer three distinct answers.

Prābhākara accepts **tripuṭī-samvit**. In every cognition, three things are simultaneously revealed: the knower, the known and the cognition. Awareness is self-manifest in the very act of presenting the object. This blocks regress: if cognition required another cognition to reveal it, an infinite chain would follow.

Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā denies that cognition is self-luminous. What becomes directly available is the object's **jñātātā** or cognizedness - its being-known. From that state one infers that a cognition has occurred. Reflexive awareness is therefore mediated, not immediate.

Nyāya rejects both self-luminosity and jñātātā-inference as the final account. It explains metacognition through **anuvyavasāya**, a higher-order cognition that takes the first cognition as its object. I first know the pot, and then I have a second cognition of the form "I know the pot."

School	First-order cognition	How second-order awareness arises	Main advantage	Main difficulty
Prābhākara	object, self and cognition appear together	immediate self-revelation	anti-regress and phenomenological economy	critics say the triad is packed too tightly
Bhāṭṭa	object is known; cognition leaves cognizedness in the object	cognition inferred from jñātātā	preserves object-realism and avoids self-luminous episodes	critics call jñātātā an unnecessary extra entity
Nyāya	object is known in the first act	anuvyavasāya reflects on that act	clear distinction between object-knowledge and metacognition	critics say regress pressure is only postponed

A good comparison also shows what each school fears most. Prābhākara fears regress, Bhāṭṭa fears collapse into self-luminous idealism or unnecessary subjectivism, and Nyāya fears making every cognition self-certifying.

Conclusion: the three schools answer the same question by privileging different epistemic goods - immediacy, mediated realism and reflective structure. The sharpest Mimamsa insight is that cognition cannot be both necessary for all knowing and completely invisible to itself.

Why this earns marks: It covers all three requested schools in a structured comparison, uses the exact technical terms, and explains the philosophical motivation behind each account instead of merely naming them.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: “A candidate who is never seen to be studying during the day time secures a high position in a competitive exam.” How would the Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Naiyāyikas explain the success of this candidate? Discuss.

Model solution

The example is a modernized **arthāpatti** case. The **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsaka** begins with two accepted facts: the candidate is never seen studying in the daytime, and yet secures a high rank. These facts are not jointly intelligible unless some unobserved preparation is postulated. Therefore the candidate must be studying at night, very early morning, or in another unobserved period. The knowledge is not inferential in the ordinary sense; it is a compelled explanatory postulation.

The **Naiyāyika** attempts to restate the case as an inference. Success in a competitive examination is regularly connected with adequate preparation. This candidate is successful. Therefore this candidate must have prepared. The unobserved preparation is established inferentially from a known relation between success and study.

School	Logical movement	Strength	Weakness
Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā	incompatible accepted facts -> necessary postulate	captures the “must be so” force of the case	critics say it can be re-described as inference
Nyāya	known relation -> inferential conclusion	keeps one unified theory of mediate knowledge	critics say the explanatory tension is being hidden inside the universal premise

Discussion: the Bhāṭṭa claims that the Naiyāyika universal is not independently available; it is extracted from the very explanatory need at issue. Nyāya replies that once the relation between success and preparation is allowed, inference is enough.

Verdict: the case is philosophically useful precisely because it sits at the boundary between postulation and inference; Bhāṭṭa says that boundary is real, Nyāya says it is reducible.

Why this earns marks: It recognizes the example as a modern arthāpatti test-case, presents both explanations fairly, and explains why the dispute survives instead of giving a one-line winner.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: On what grounds do the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas reject memory as a source of knowledge? Discuss.

Model solution

Both Prābhākaras and Naiyāyikas reject memory as a **pramāṇa** because memory lacks the **novel presentational force** that belongs to genuine means of knowledge. It depends on a prior cognition and a residual mental trace.

For the **Prābhākaras**, a **pramāṇa** must produce fresh cognition of an object. Memory simply reproduces what has already been known. It does not disclose an object as presently given; rather, it recalls what was previously apprehended. Its dependence on earlier knowledge is therefore intrinsic to its non-pramāṇic character.

The **Naiyāyikas** reach a similar conclusion from a different angle. Valid cognition must arise from the proper operation of a **pramāṇa** such as perception, inference, comparison or testimony. Memory does not arise from present contact with an object, a current inferential mark, a live comparison or a fresh utterance. It arises from a **saṃskāra** left by earlier cognition. Therefore it may be true, but it is not knowledge newly generated by a **pramāṇa**.

Ground of rejection	Prābhākara emphasis	Nyāya emphasis
lack of novelty	decisive	decisive
dependence on prior cognition	explicit criterion	implicit through saṃskāra theory
present disclosure	absent	absent
truth-value	memory may be true	memory may be true

Conclusion: both schools reject memory not because it is false, but because it is derivative and non-originate. The shared criterion is novelty; the main difference lies in the wider epistemological systems in which that criterion is embedded.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact “grounds” asked for, gives both schools separately, and avoids the common mistake of calling memory invalid simply because it looks backward.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Delineate the main points of difference between the theory of intrinsic validation (svataḥ prāmāṇyavāda) and theory of extrinsic validation (parataḥ prāmāṇyavāda) in classical Indian philosophy.

Model solution

The difference concerns both the **source** of validity and the **way** validity becomes known.

In **svataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda**, defended classically by Mīmāṃsā, cognition is valid by its own occurrence under normal conditions. It presents itself as trustworthy and is acted upon unless defeated by later contradiction or discovery of defect. Invalidity is therefore extrinsic and subsequent.

In **parataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda**, associated in the standard contrast with Nyāya, the mere occurrence of cognition does not suffice for its validation. Truth is secured through something outside the cognition itself - successful action, later confirming cognition, or reflective assessment.

Issue	Svataḥ-prāmāṇya	Parataḥ-prāmāṇya
initial status	prima facie valid	not fully validated by bare occurrence
need for external certificate	no	yes
invalidity	discovered through later defect or contradiction	built into validation process through external checks
strongest Mimamsa argument	avoids infinite regress and matches practical life	Nyāya says this leaves cognition under-verified
strongest Nyāya concern	Mimamsa says it risks regress and hidden prior trust	avoids gullibility and demands verification

Conclusion: the first begins with trust and allows correction later; the second begins with the need for validation and risks regress unless it can explain how validating cognition itself becomes acceptable.

Why this earns marks: It delineates the doctrine on exactly the requested axis, uses the standard school contrast, and states the decisive strength of each side in one compact answer.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025 Q6(c), 15 marks

Question: Discuss the debate between the Bhaṭṭa and the Prabhākara mīmāṃsakas with reference to the nature of Non-existence (Abhāva) and its knowledge.

Model solution

The debate turns on two linked questions: **what is abhāva?** and **how is it known?**

The **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas** hold that non-existence is a real negative content capable of cognition. If I know that the jar is absent from the floor, the absence is not merely a linguistic convenience; it is an object structured by the relation to its counterpositive, the jar. Since perception requires contact with a present object, and inference requires a sign,

Bhāṭṭa treats absence-cognition as requiring a distinct pramāṇa: **anupalabdhi**.

The **Prābhākara**s refuse both the extra ontology and the extra pramāṇa. What is directly cognized is the locus itself, unqualified by the absent object. The floor is simply presented as jar-less. Hence there is no need to introduce a separate means of knowledge.

Issue	Bhāṭṭa	Prābhākara
nature of abhāva	real negative content	no denial of the judgment, but no independent negative entity is needed
knowledge of absence	anupalabdhi	ordinary cognition of the bare locus
motivation	preserve the determinacy of negative cognition	preserve epistemic and ontological economy
main problem	multiplies pramāṇas and objects	may not fully explain the determinacy of “absence of X”

The deepest disagreement is methodological. Bhāṭṭa is willing to posit new epistemic resources when experience demands them. Prābhākara is more austere and prefers to avoid multiplication unless reduction fails completely.

Verdict: Bhāṭṭa offers the fuller account of negative cognition; Prābhākara offers the leaner account. The choice depends on whether explanatory adequacy or economy is treated as philosophically decisive.

Why this earns marks: It centers the answer on the exact two-fold debate - nature and knowledge of abhāva - and concludes with the underlying methodological contrast between the two sub-schools.

Original MCQ Bank - 32 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Mīmāṃsā begins with: A. inquiry into dharma B. proof of God C. denial of self D. mystical union	A	The school starts from dharma-jijñāsā, not from speculative theology.
2	In the Mimamsa context, codanā means: A. memory of duty B. impelling Vedic injunction C. comparison-based cognition D. prior non-existence	B	Codanā is the command-form that makes duty action-guiding.
3	Which school accepts six pramāṇas? A. Nyāya B. Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā C. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā D. Sāṃkhya	C	Bhāṭṭa adds anupalabdhi to the five accepted by Prābhākara.
4	Memory is denied pramāṇa-status chiefly because it: A. is always false B. depends on God C. lacks semantic fitness D. does not disclose a previously unknown object	D	Novelty is the decisive criterion.
5	Svataḥ-prāmāṇya says that cognition is: A. prima facie valid by its own occurrence B. permanently infallible C. created by language D. valid only after success	A	Intrinsic validity means default trust, not incorrigibility.
6	Parataḥ-apramāṇya means that invalidity is known through: A. intuition alone B. later contradiction or discovery of defect C. universals only D. deep sleep	B	Falsity is externally disclosed.
7	The stout Devadatta case is the classical example of: A. anupalabdhi B. anuvyavasāya C. arthāpatti D. sphoṭa	C	The conclusion is compelled explanatory postulation.
8	Nyāya's reduction of arthāpatti relies most on a prior: A. niyoga B. apūrva C. akhyāti D. vyāpti	D	It tries to convert the case into standard inference.
9	Yogyānupalabdhi requires that the absent object: A. would be perceivable if present B. be eternal C. be remembered from childhood D. be scripturally revealed	A	Non-perception counts only when perception should have occurred.
10	According to Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, abhāva is: A. mere grammar B. a real negative content known by anupalabdhi C. impossible to cognize D. always inferential only	B	Bhāṭṭa grants both objecthood and a separate pramāṇa.
11	Tripuṭi-samvit means simultaneous manifestation of: A. three Vedas B. word, meaning and sentence C. knower, known and cognition D. duty, fruit and God	C	This is the Prābhākara answer to metacognition.
12	Jñātātā refers to the object's: A. falsity B. universality C. ritual purity D. cognizedness, from which cognition is inferred	D	Kumārila denies self-luminosity of cognition and infers it from jñātātā.
13	Akhyāti explains illusion as: A. non-discrimination between perception and memory B. divine deception C. pure non-being D. only linguistic confusion	A	Prābhākara keeps the constituent cognitions valid.
14	Viparīta-khyāti holds that illusion involves: A. only recollection B. a positive misapprehension under defect C. no cognition at all D. mere verbal error	B	Bhāṭṭa allows a false cognition without abandoning intrinsic validity.
15	Abhihitānvayavāda states that: A. words mean only particulars B. Veda has a divine author C. words first denote separate meanings and then get connected D. sentences alone are primary	C	This is the Bhāṭṭa theory of sentence meaning.
16	Anvitābhidhānavāda states that words convey: A. only remembered objects B. abstract sounds without meaning C. bare universals alone D. meanings as already connected in sentential use	D	This is the Prābhākara contextualist position.
17	Ākāṅkṣā in sentence theory means: A. mutual expectancy among words B. speaker's private intention C. absence-cognition D. non-verbal meditation	A	Without expectancy, sentence unity does not arise.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
18	Mīmāṃsā generally gives semantic priority to: A. silence B. universals (jāti) C. divine intention D. impossible objects	B	Repeatable application of a word is explained through jāti.
19	Apauruṣeyatva primarily protects the Veda from: A. ritual complexity B. historical transmission C. authorial defect D. sentence-unity	C	No human or divine author means no author-based error.
20	The strongest Mimamsa reason to reject a creator-God is that God would: A. abolish perception B. destroy universals C. remove duty D. become redundant beside karma and apūrva or introduce partiality	D	This is the classic anti-theistic pressure point.
21	Śābdī bhāvanā is the: A. linguistic impelling force of the injunction B. bare-locus cognition of absence C. theory of memory D. post-mokṣa bliss	A	It explains how the Vedic word moves the agent to act.
22	Ārthī bhāvanā is the: A. eternity of words B. real productive force of the performed act C. relation between universal and particular D. later reflective cognition	B	It explains how action brings about the result.
23	Prābhākara's niyoga-vāda emphasizes: A. phala as the sole motive B. God's command C. the act as directly binding and to-be-done D. memory as duty	C	Duty arises from injunction itself, not merely from desired fruit.
24	Apūrva is best described as: A. a visible ritual fire B. a universal C. God in hidden form D. an unseen potency linking act and later fruit	D	It explains delayed ritual efficacy without theism.
25	Ritual deities in classical Mimamsa are primarily: A. mantra-denoted participants within sacrificial procedure B. creators of the world C. deniers of Veda D. equivalent to Brahman	A	They are not the sovereign dispensers of fruit.
26	Vedānta challenges Mimamsa by insisting that some Vedic sentences reveal: A. only ritual accessories B. an already accomplished reality (siddha-vastu) C. bare universals without context D. only social law	B	This marks the break between Pūrva- and Uttara-Mīmāṃsā.
27	The self in Mimamsa must be: A. momentary B. identical with language C. enduring as knower, agent and enjoyer D. unreal like illusion	C	Without continuity, karma and ritual fruit collapse.
28	Later Mimamsa mokṣa is best stated as: A. union with Īśvara B. absorption into language C. public ritual prestige D. cessation of suffering and embodiment, not Brahman-identity	D	The doctrine is largely negative and should not be Vedāntized.
29	The statement "intrinsic validity means every cognition is permanently true" is: A. false because Mimamsa allows later defeat B. true because default trust is infallible C. true only for memory D. true only for error	A	The standard trap is to confuse default validity with final indefeasibility.
30	Nyāya explains awareness of cognition through: A. apūrva B. anuvyavasāya C. codanā D. akhyāti	B	A higher-order cognition reflects on the first act of knowing.
31	In ritual hermeneutics, vākya chiefly concerns: A. the historical author B. similarity with another ritual C. sentence-unity and connected textual meaning D. deep sleep	C	Vākya is one of the ranked interpretive clues.
32	The safest one-line summary of the topic is: A. theology in search of omniscience B. skepticism about all knowledge C. mysticism without duty D. knowledge in the service of dharma	D	That formula keeps epistemology tied to language, duty and ritual action.

Rotation audit: A -> B -> C -> D repeated eight times.

Remedial Error-Correction Drills

Drill	Common wrong move	Corrective repair	Why the correction matters
1	"Intrinsic validity means no cognition can ever be false."	Say: every cognition is prima facie valid, but later defeat can reveal falsity.	This prevents infallibilist misreading.
2	"Prābhākara accepts six pramāṇas like Bhāṭṭa."	Say: Prābhākara accepts five ; Bhāṭṭa alone adds anupalabdhi .	This is one of the most repeated factual traps.
3	"Arthāpatti is just a fancy name for guesswork."	Say: it is compelled postulation produced by otherwise unresolved incompatibility.	The exam asks for its irreducible logic, not its superficial plausibility.
4	"Akhyāti means there is no cognition at all in illusion."	Say: there are valid cognitions, but their difference is not discriminated .	Without this, Prābhākara's theory collapses into absurdity.
5	"Bhāṭṭa accepts self-luminous cognition."	Say: Bhāṭṭa defends intrinsic validity but knows cognition through jñātātā .	This is the decisive distinction between manifestation and validity.
6	"Mīmāṃsā proves Veda by invoking God."	Say: it secures the Veda by excluding divine authorship and defending apauruṣeyatva .	This preserves the school's distinctive orthodoxy-without-theism.
7	"Niyoga and desire for fruit mean the same thing."	Say: Prābhākara makes obligation categorical, while Bhāṭṭa allows a stronger place for phala-motivation.	This prevents flattening the Bhāṭṭa-Prābhākara ethical divide.
8	"Mokṣa in Mimamsa is merger into Brahman."	Say: later Mimamsa generally presents mokṣa negatively, as release from pain and embodiment.	This blocks Vedāntic importation into a ritual-epistemic school.

Original Mains Practice

Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain how codanā, bhāvanā and apūrva together make Mīmāṃsā a theory of duty rather than a mere theory of knowledge.

Model solution

Codanā makes Vedic language prescriptive: dharma is known as what the Veda enjoins. **Bhāvanā** explains how that injunction works. In Bhāṭṭa terms, **śābdī bhāvanā** impels the qualified agent to act, while **ārthī bhāvanā** belongs to the actual performance that produces the result. **Apūrva** then links the visible but perishing act to a later unseen fruit.

These three ideas therefore form one chain. Codanā gives duty its linguistic form, bhāvanā gives injunction its motivational and productive structure, and apūrva secures delayed efficacy without requiring a creator-God. Without codanā, the Veda would become descriptive; without bhāvanā, command would not generate action; without apūrva, the gap between act and fruit would remain unexplained.

A Vedāntin may object that this subordinates too much scriptural meaning to action. Mīmāṃsā accepts the price because its project is not metaphysical disclosure first, but the determination of dharma.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive through one integrated chain, uses the exact technical terms, and shows how language, action and unseen efficacy fit together.

Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Is Prābhākara's tripuṭī-samvit a stronger account of self-awareness than Nyāya anuvyavasāya and Bhāṭṭa jñātātā? Evaluate.

Model solution

Prābhākara's **tripuṭī-samvit** is powerful because it meets the regress objection most directly. If cognition were not somehow manifest in the very act of knowing, another cognition would be needed to reveal it, and that second cognition would need a third. By holding that knower, known and cognition are given together, Prābhākara preserves immediacy.

Against this, **Nyāya** offers **anuvyavasāya** - a second-order cognition of the form "I know the pot." Its strength is analytic clarity: it sharply separates object-knowledge from reflective awareness. Its weakness is that the regress worry does not fully disappear; one must explain why the higher-order cognition does not require a further one.

Bhāṭṭa avoids both full self-luminosity and explicit second-order reflection by appealing to **jñātātā**. Cognition is inferred from the object's cognizedness. This preserves a stronger object-realism, but critics complain that jñātātā looks like an extra entity introduced only to avoid self-manifest cognition.

Evaluation: tripuṭī-samvit is strongest if anti-regress economy is treated as decisive. Nyāya is strongest if reflective structure is prioritized. Bhāṭṭa is strongest if one wants reflexive awareness without granting self-luminous episodes. No single theory is cost-free.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates rather than merely lists, explains the different philosophical motivations, and gives a balanced verdict instead of a one-sided assertion.

Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: Can Mīmāṃsā consistently defend an authorless Veda, deny God, and still claim objective normativity? Discuss.

Model solution

Mīmāṃsā answers this challenge by shifting the ground of normativity away from divine will and toward the objective authority of an **apauruṣeya** text. The Veda is authorless, eternal and free from the defects that plague personal testimony. Because dharma is supersensible, no ordinary pramāṇa can independently generate it; Vedic injunction is therefore uniquely authoritative in its own domain.

Normativity enters through **codanā** and **niyoga / bhāvanā**. A Vedic sentence is not merely descriptive but action-guiding. Duty binds because the injunction itself presents an act as to-be-done for a qualified agent. This impersonal model removes dependence on a lawgiver. The later fruit of obedience is explained by **apūrva**, the unseen potency produced by correct action. Thus Mīmāṃsā can deny a creator-God while still offering a structured account of obligation and efficacy.

The position is internally coherent, but not unproblematic. **Nyāya** objects that meaning and authority are easier to understand if grounded in an omniscient author. **Buddhist** critics deny eternal words and natural word-meaning relations. **Advaita** objects that not all Vedic meaning is injunctive, since Upaniṣadic statements reveal an accomplished reality. Further, critics may ask whether apūrva and authorless language are explanatory successes or theoretical devices designed to rescue ritualism.

Yet Mīmāṃsā has a real philosophical achievement: it shows that objective normativity need not be equated with divine command. A text can bind, on this model, because of its impersonal validity, stable semantic force and exclusive access to a supersensible domain.

Verdict: within its own realist and hermeneutic presuppositions, Mīmāṃsā can consistently defend objective normativity without God. Its deepest vulnerability lies not in inconsistency, but in the contested assumptions of eternal language and unseen efficacy.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the system's internal coherence, brings in rival objections, and ends with a graded verdict that distinguishes inconsistency from contestability.